

WHAT'S THE BIG DEAL WITH "DIMINISHED?"

FROM DIGGING DEEPER JAZZ VIDEOS #72

So, when was the past time you saw a Diminished Chord change in a jazz tune? Maybe once in the last ten songs you looked at. Or, relative to other chords qualities (major, minor, dominant, half diminished), how often do you actually see a Diminished Chord? 2% of the time maybe? So, what's the big deal with Diminished scales, licks, and devices if we rarely even see those chords in a piece of music . . . ?

Here's The Big Deal: there are Diminished Chords hiding INSIDE Dominant Chords. Diminished Chords are like parasites, living inside Dominant Chords. It's kind of gross. But it's also kind of awesome. What this means is that we can play Diminished material (licks, devices, scales, root motions) over Dominant Chords. Kind of awesome, right?

1 - Dominant Chord w/ Diminished Chord inside it

The notation shows a C7 chord (C4, E4, G4, Bb4) and a C7(b9) chord (C4, E4, G4, Bb4, Bb5). To the right, the E diminished chord is shown as a scale: E4, G4, Bb4, Db5, E5. The notes are labeled 1, 3, 5, b7, b9.

2 - Our new "Root Motion" - Minor 3rds

The notation shows a sequence of notes: E4, G4, Bb4, Db5, E5. Each note is a minor third above the previous one, indicated by "(m 3rd)".

All these notes (E, G, Bb, Db, E) are a minor third apart.

3

The notation shows a C7 chord (C4, E4, G4, Bb4) and a sequence of licks: (1 - 7 - 1), (1 - 7 - 1), (1 - 7 - 1), (1 - 7 - 1). The notes are E4, G4, Bb4, Db5, E5.

Here, we take a SIMPLE lick (1-7-1) and run it through our Root Motion of minor 3rds.

4

The notation shows a C7 chord (C4, E4, G4, Bb4) and a sequence of licks: (1 - 2 - b3), (1 - 2 - b3), (1 - 2 - b3), (1 - 2 - b3). The notes are E4, G4, Bb4, Db5, E5.

Another SIMPLE lick, (1 - 2 - b3) run through our Root Motion of minor 3rds.